agency for no profit and for the good of the community. It was a lesson in using free-market means to ridicule free-market ends.

The uncertainty that surrounded our daily life – our home, our gas and electricity connections and such – was mirrored in our night-time activities. Each of us in the International Subversives knew that the police were seeking to make an example of us. The Australian Academic and Research Network were co-operating with the Australian Federal Police in order to try and catch us, and we were able to hack into their various systems to see how close they were getting. Our nemesis in the police even had a name, Sergeant Ken Day, and he seemed to have become obsessed with our activities. To us he was just a name at the time, though we came to know him well after our arrests, which he had worked so hard for. (It is one of the ironies of my life that Ken Day would later become a strong supporter of WikiLeaks in the Australian press.) We were visiting systems and learning from them, but, as hackers, we were also fairly competitive, each wanting to be first. I would work hard to create Trojans, ways of tricking a computer system into letting you inside and believing you are the legitimate user, which encouraged it to give up its secrets to you. All good, clean fun, except it was the kind of fun that made authorities crazy. We were basically turning ourselves into people who had the power of system administrators over many powerful networks.

The net closed in on us with Nortel, the system belonging to the Canadian telecommunications company that ran a network stretching over the globe. It had been one of our greatest explorations. There were more than 11,000 computers in Nortel's network, and we had fought long and hard to gain access to them. From Melbourne, I had commandeered, or hijacked, forty computers housed in Canada, with the intention of bombarding Nortel with guesses as to their passwords. The program I'd designed could throw 40,000 guesses per second. Eventually we got in and it was like walking inside the Sistine Chapel at midnight. You could look at all the expertise, all the evidence of civilisation, and notice their methods, their habits, their corners of liturgy and mystery. We had root control within that system and could have transferred money or sold their commercial secrets. But we did none of those things. Prime Suspect, Trax and myself would have considered that the lowest move. We were above that kind of dirt, wanting simply to master the system and move on.